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Political Science

Recent Issues and Challenges

Official Syllabus · Politics in India Since Independence · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Politics in India Since Independence)	Skills the questions test
Globalisation & LPG Reforms	Challenge of and responses to globalization: new economic policy and its opposition.	Identifying the 1991 balance-of-payments crisis, structural adjustment policies, and multi-sectoral resistance (trade unions, farmers, cultural critics).
Rise of OBCs in North India	Rise of Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in North Indian politics.	Tracing the political rise of intermediate peasant castes (Yadavs, Kurmis) post-Mandal, and the emergence of regional parties (SP, RJD, JD(U)).
Dalit Politics: Electoral Arena	Dalit politics in the electoral arena: Kanshi Ram and the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP).	Differentiating BAMCEF (1978), DS-4 (1981), and BSP (1984); analyzing Mayawati's political alliances and social engineering.
Dalit Politics: Non-Electoral Arena	Dalit politics in the non-electoral arena: Dalit Panthers and subaltern assertion.	Recalling Dalit Panthers (1972, Maharashtra, Namdeo Dhasal/ J.V. Pawar), literary resistance, and the SC/ST Prevention of Atrocities Act, 1989.
Communalism & Ayodhya Dispute	Challenge of communalism: Ayodhya dispute, 1992 demolition, and communal violence.	Sequencing key events: 1986 court order, 1990 Rath Yatra, 6 December 1992 demolition, imposition of Article 356, and 2002 Gujarat riots.

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Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Politics in India Since Independence)	Skills the questions test
Debates on Indian Secularism	Secularism in Indian politics: Constitutional model versus communal challenges.	Contrasting Indian 'principled distance' with Western 'wall of separation'; evaluating minority rights and state-sponsored social reform.

CUET UG Exam Strategy — Chapter 8 Focus

- **Pattern:** 50 Multiple Choice Questions (attempt any 40) in 60 minutes.
- **Marking:** +5 marks for correct choice, −1 mark negative deduction for incorrect choice.
- **High-Yield Angles:** Kanshi Ram's three organizations (BAMCEF, DS-4, BSP), Dalit Panthers founders and origins, exact dates of the Ayodhya dispute, Supreme Court intervention in Gujarat riots, and critiques of economic liberalization.

1. Challenge of and Responses to Globalisation

In mid-1991, India abandoned four decades of state-dominated economic planning in response to a crippling macroeconomic crisis, embarking on structural integration with the global economy.

The 1991 Balance of Payments Crisis

- **Exhaustion of Foreign Exchange:** By June 1991, India's foreign exchange reserves plummeted to approximately $1.2 billion, barely sufficient to finance two weeks of essential imports.
- **Underlying Causes:** Massive fiscal deficits, the Gulf War (1990–91) which spiked global oil prices and halted Gulf remittances, and unsustainable external commercial borrowings.
- **Emergency Measures:** The caretaker Chandra Shekhar government pledged 67 tonnes of gold reserves to the Bank of England and Union Bank of Switzerland to avert sovereign default.

The New Economic Policy (NEP)

- **Leadership:** Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao and Finance Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh unveiled structural adjustment reforms under the rubric of **LPG (Liberalisation, Privatisation, Globalisation)**.
- **Key Reform Measures:**
  - **Delicensing & Deregulation:** Dismantled the "Licence-Permit-Quota Raj" across most manufacturing sectors.
  - **Foreign Direct Investment (FDI):** Lifted restrictions on foreign equity ownership, encouraging multinational corporations.

- **Trade Liberalisation:** Slashed peak customs tariffs, abolished quantitative import restrictions, and joined the World Trade Organization (WTO) as a founding member in 1995.
- **Disinvestment:** Initiated the partial sale of government equity in Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs).

Multi-Dimensional Resistance to Globalisation

- **Trade Union & Labour Opposition:**
  - Left-wing central trade unions (AITUC, CITU) organized nationwide general strikes protesting retrenchment, the closure of unviable industrial units, contract labor casualization, and the erosion of social security.
- **Agrarian & Farmers' Movements:**
  - Organizations such as the Bharatiya Kisan Union (BKU) and Karnataka Rajya Raitha Sangha (KRRS) led by M.D. Nanjundaswamy fiercely opposed WTO intellectual property regimes (TRIPS).
  - Farmers resisted the patenting of indigenous seeds (e.g., Neem, Basmati rice) by multinational corporations and agitated against the withdrawal of fertilizer, water, and electricity subsidies.
- **Cultural Resistance:**
  - Both Left cultural platforms and right-wing nationalist groups (Swadeshi Jagran Manch) protested against Western consumerism, commercialization of culture, and vulgarization of public life (manifested in protests against beauty pageants and Valentine's Day celebrations).

2. Rise of OBCs in North Indian Politics

The implementation of the Mandal Commission recommendations permanently reshaped political representation across the Hindi heartland.

Social Background: The Intermediate Peasantry

- **Impact of the Green Revolution:** The Green Revolution in the late 1960s economically enriched middle and intermediate agricultural castes (such as Yadavs, Kurmis, Lodhs, Koeris, and Jats) across Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Haryana, and Rajasthan.
- **Disproportionate Political Under-representation:** Despite their substantial demographic strength (roughly 52% of the population) and growing rural economic clout, backward castes occupied fewer than 5% of elite administrative positions (IAS, IPS) and were under-represented in parliamentary leadership.

Post-Mandal Political Mobilization

- **Caste as an Electoral Force:** The Mandal controversy in 1990 galvanized backward castes to reject upper-caste Congress dominance and vote for their own caste leadership.
- **Rise of Regional Identity Parties:**
  - **Samajwadi Party (SP):** Founded in 1992 by Mulayam Singh Yadav, mobilizing a potent social coalition of Other Backward Classes (primarily Yadavs) and religious minorities in Uttar Pradesh.

- **Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD):** Founded in 1997 by Lalu Prasad Yadav, pioneering the powerful "MY" (Muslim-Yadav) electoral coalition in Bihar.
- **Janata Dal (United) - JD(U):** Mobilized Non-Yadav OBCs (Kurmis, Koeris) and Extremely Backward Castes (EBCs) under Nitish Kumar.

- **Shift in Hegemony:** Traditional upper-caste hegemony over northern Indian politics was permanently broken, establishing backward caste leaders as undisputed kingmakers in federal coalition building.

3. Dalit Politics: Electoral Assertion (Kanshi Ram & BSP)

Dalit political assertion in the post-1980s era shifted dramatically from dependent clientelism to an autonomous quest for political supremacy.

Kanshi Ram's Organizational Architecture

Kanshi Ram, a former government research scientist from Punjab, recognized that Dalits could never achieve liberation by remaining subordinate vote-banks of upper-caste-dominated parties. He built an organizational apparatus across three distinct phases:

- **1. BAMCEF (1978):**
  - The **Backward and Minority Communities Employees Federation** was founded on 6 December 1978.
  - It functioned as a non-political, non-electoral union of educated, employed Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, OBCs, and religious minority government servants.
  - **Purpose:** To pool financial resources and intellectual talent from salaried Dalit employees to support grassroots social campaigns ("Pay back to society").
- **2. DS-4 (1981):**
  - The **Dalit Shoshit Samaj Sangharsh Samiti** was established in December 1981.
  - It served as an activist, quasi-political agitational wing to mobilize students, youth, and workers through cycle rallies, street theater, and direct protests against caste discrimination.
- **3. Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP, 1984):**
  - Founded on **14 April 1984** (Dr. B.R. Ambedkar's birth anniversary) as a formal political party.
  - **Core Ideology:** The concept of the **"Bahujan"** (the majority), uniting Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST), Other Backward Classes (OBC), and religious minorities—who together constituted 85% of India's population—against the 15% upper-caste ruling elite.

Mayawati and the Capture of State Power

- **Rise to Chief Ministership (1995):** Mayawati was sworn in as the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh in June 1995 with outside support from the BJP, becoming the **first Dalit woman Chief Minister** of any Indian state.
- **Pragmatic Power Coalitions:** BSP entered into short-term tactical alliances with both the Samajwadi Party (1993) and the BJP (1995, 1997, 2002) to capture state power, arguing that political power is the master key to social dignity.

- **Social Engineering (2007):** In the 2007 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections, Mayawati forged a historic rainbow coalition of Dalits, Brahmins, Muslims, and OBCs, securing 206 seats and winning the **first single-party absolute majority in Uttar Pradesh in 16 years**.

4. Dalit Politics: Non-Electoral Assertion (Dalit Panthers)

While the BSP pursued power through electoral ballots, subaltern communities in Maharashtra pioneered militant grassroots resistance against physical atrocities and socio-economic exclusion.

Origins of the Dalit Panthers

- **Founding (May 1972):** Established in the industrial slums of Bombay (now Mumbai) by young Dalit writers, poets, and activists led by **Namdeo Dhasal**, **J.V. Pawar**, and **Arjun Dangle**.
- **Inspiration:** Inspired by the militant African-American **Black Panther Party** in the United States, which fought institutional racism through armed self-defense and community assertion.
- **Radical Manifesto:** Defined "Dalit" expansively to include all exploited classes—Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, neo-Buddhists, landless laborers, and impoverished peasants.

Modes of Struggle and Achievements

- **Direct Physical Resistance:** Rebuffed violent caste atrocities, boycotted discriminatory village panchayats, and provided organized physical protection to rural Dalit victims of feudal violence in the Marathwada and Vidarbha regions.
- **Dalit Literary Renaissance:** Spearheaded the "Little Magazine Movement", creating revolutionary Marathi poetry, short stories, and raw autobiographical prose that exposed the visceral realities of untouchability, shattering orthodox literary conventions.
- **Legislative Impact:** Constant agitation against institutional violence pushed the Indian Parliament to pass the stringent **Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989**.
- **Decline and Fragmentation:** Beset by internal ideological conflicts—between Marxist class struggle (Namdeo Dhasal) and Buddhist-Ambedkarite cultural focus (Raja Dhale)—the Dalit Panthers formally fragmented in 1977, dissolving into multiple competing factions.

5. Challenge of Communalism & The Ayodhya Dispute

The dispute over the historic structure at Ayodhya became the most polarizing communal and political controversy in post-independence India.

Chronology of the Ayodhya Controversy

- **December 1949:** Idols of Lord Ram were clandestinely placed inside the three-domed 16th-century Babri Masjid in Ayodhya. The district administration locked the premises to prevent violent clashes, declaring it a disputed property.

- **February 1986 (The Unlocking of Gates):** The Faizabad District Judge ordered the locks of the structure opened to allow Hindu devotees to offer prayers. The Rajiv Gandhi government did not contest the order, hoping to appease Hindu sentiment following the controversial Shah Bano controversy.
- **Polarized Mobilization (Late 1980s):**
  - The Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP), Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), and BJP launched a nationwide movement to construct a magnificent Ram Temple at the site, believed to be the birthplace of Lord Ram (**Ram Janmabhoomi**).
  - The Babri Masjid Action Committee (BMAC) was formed to protect the historical mosque and demand the restitution of minority worship rights.
- **Advani's Rath Yatra (September–October 1990):**
  - BJP President Lal Krishna Advani launched an extensive motorized **Rath Yatra** from Somnath (Gujarat) to Ayodhya.
  - Advani's arrest in Samastipur (Bihar) by Chief Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav led the BJP to pull down the National Front government of V.P. Singh.
- **The Demolition (6 December 1992):**
  - Thousands of volunteer **Karsevaks** organized by the VHP and BJP assembled in Ayodhya for a symbolic rally.
  - Defying Supreme Court assurances given by the Uttar Pradesh state government, mobs breached police cordons and demolished the 16th-century structure within hours.
  - Chief Minister Kalyan Singh resigned that evening, and the Central government imposed President's Rule under Article 356.

Repercussions and Constitutional Fallout

- **Communal Riots (1992–1993):** The demolition triggered severe communal riots across north India, most tragically in Mumbai in December 1992 and January 1993, followed by the serial bomb blasts in March 1993.
- **Dismissal of State Governments:** The Narasimha Rao Central government dismissed all four BJP-ruled state governments (Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Himachal Pradesh). In the landmark **S.R. Bommai Case (1994)**, the Supreme Court upheld these dismissals, ruling that **secularism is part of the Basic Structure of the Constitution**.
- **Liberhan Commission:** Justice M.S. Liberhan was appointed to probe the sequence of events leading to the demolition; submitted its comprehensive report in 2009 after 17 years.
- **Supreme Court Verdict (November 2019):** A unanimous 5-judge Supreme Court bench awarded the entire disputed 2.77-acre site to a government trust for the construction of a Ram temple, while directing the allocation of an alternative 5-acre plot in Ayodhya for a mosque.

6. The 2002 Gujarat Riots

In February–March 2002, Gujarat experienced widespread communal violence that raised profound questions regarding administrative neutrality and minority safety.

The Sequence of Violence

- **Godhra Train Burning (27 February 2002):** Coach S-6 of the Sabarmati Express carrying Hindu pilgrims (**Karsevaks**) returning from Ayodhya was set on fire at Godhra railway station, killing 57 passengers.
- **Subsequent Communal Riots:** Widespread communal violence engulfed Ahmedabad, Vadodara, and rural Gujarat over the following weeks, resulting in the death of over 1,000 people (predominantly Muslims), mass sexual violence, and the internal displacement of over 150,000 citizens.

Institutional and Judicial Intervention

- **National Human Rights Commission (NHRC):** Intervened decisively, criticizing the state administration for failing to protect vulnerable citizens and calling for impartial investigations.
- **Supreme Court Monitoring:**
  - In an extraordinary move to guarantee fair justice, the Supreme Court transferred key high-profile trial cases (such as the **Best Bakery Case**) out of Gujarat to Maharashtra courts.
  - The apex court set up a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to reopen and re-investigate hundreds of riot cases that had been summarily closed by local police.

7. Debates on Indian Secularism

The communal challenges of the 1990s and 2000s forced a thorough re-examination of secularism as practiced in India versus its Western counterparts.

Analytical Dimension	Western Secularism (Strict Separation)	Indian Secularism (Principled Distance)
State & Religion Relationship	Mutual exclusion; strict "wall of separation". State does not aid, finance, or intervene in religious institutions.	Principled distance. State maintains equal distance from all religions (**Sarva Dharma Sambhava**) without total detachment.
State-Sponsored Reform	State cannot intervene in religious dogmas, rituals, or internal social customs.	State actively intervenes to reform oppressive social practices (e.g., banning untouchability, sati, child marriage, and opening temples to all).
Minority Protection	Focuses solely on individual citizen rights; little or no constitutional accommodation for group-differentiated minority culture.	Explicit constitutional guarantees: Articles 29 and 30 grant religious and linguistic minorities rights to establish and administer their own educational institutions.

Analytical Dimension	Western Secularism (Strict Separation)	Indian Secularism (Principled Distance)
Contemporary Criticisms	Accused of being anti-religious and insensitive to deeply religious pluralist societies.	Critics allege "minority appeasement", pseudo-secularism, or vote-bank politics; defenders stress equal respect and communal harmony.

The Whole Chapter in One Picture



Figure 1: Contemporary Challenges & Resistance Matrix: The four pillars (Globalisation, OBC rise, Dalit politics, Communalism), Kanshi Ram's organizations, and secularism debates.

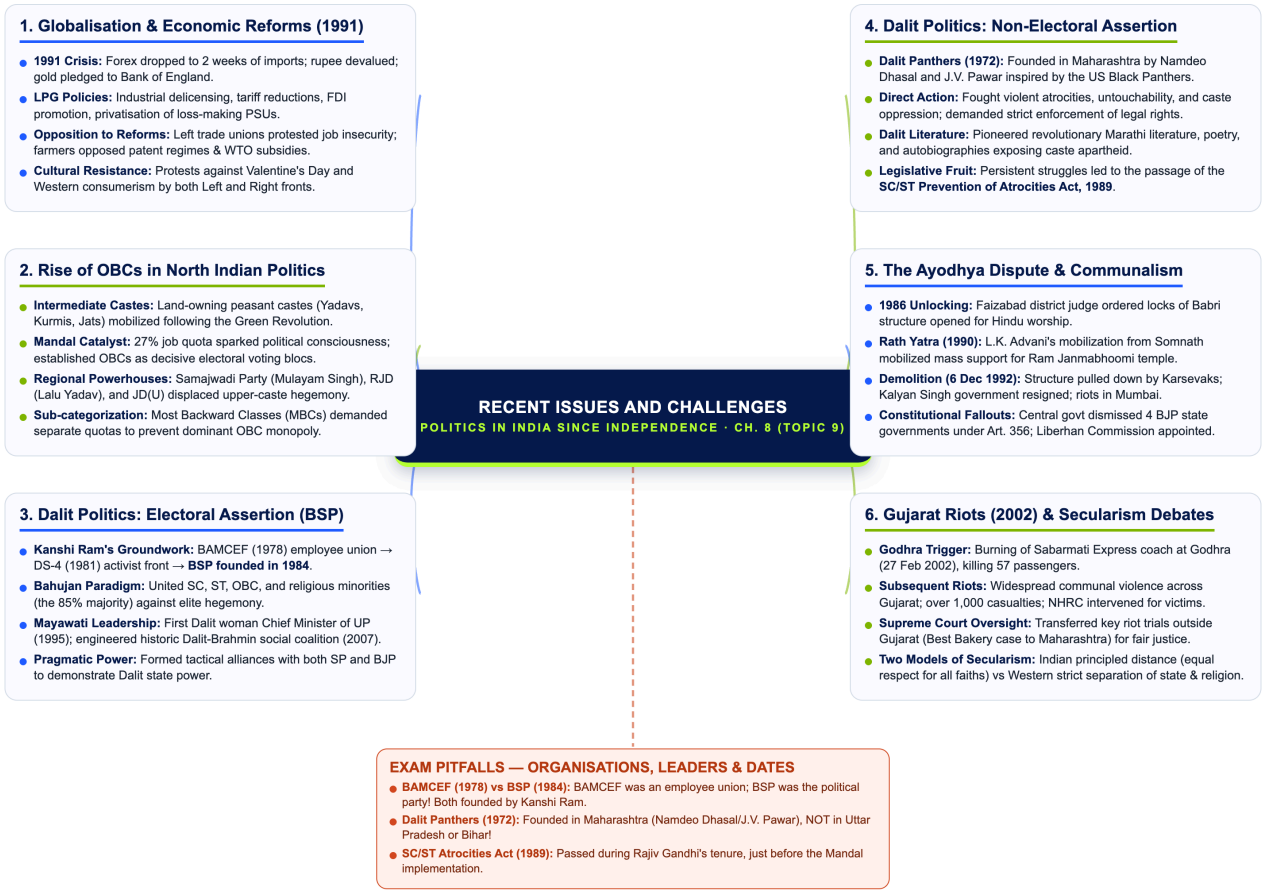


Figure 2: Complete Chapter Mindmap: 1991 economic reforms, intermediate caste assertion, BAMCEF and Dalit Panthers, Ayodhya dispute chronology, and the Gujarat riots.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions designed in authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. In June 1991, roughly how much foreign exchange reserves remained with the Indian government, triggering the adoption of structural economic reforms?

(A) Barely 2 weeks of imports
(B) Nearly 6 months of imports
(C) Over 1 year of imports
(D) Sufficient for 3 months of imports

Q2. Which prominent farmers' leader led the Karnataka Rajya Raitha Sangha (KRRS) in militant direct actions against WTO patent regimes and multinational seed corporations?

(A) Mahendra Singh Tikait
(B) Sharad Joshi
(C) M.D. Nanjundaswamy
(D) Chaudhary Charan Singh

Q3. Which organization was founded by Kanshi Ram in 1978 as a non-political federation of government employees from backward and minority communities?

(A) Dalit Shoshit Samaj Sangharsh Samiti (DS-4) **(B)** Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP)
(C) BAMCEF **(D)** Dalit Panthers

Q4. The militant social organization 'Dalit Panthers' was founded in which Indian state in May 1972?

(A) Uttar Pradesh **(B)** Bihar
(C) Maharashtra **(D)** Punjab

Q5. Who among the following was a renowned Marathi poet and co-founder of the Dalit Panthers who authored the radical collection 'Golpitha'?

(A) Namdeo Dhasal **(B)** Kanshi Ram
(C) Ram Vilas Paswan **(D)** B.R. Ambedkar

Q6. In which year did the Faizabad District Court order the opening of the locks of the disputed Babri structure in Ayodhya to allow Hindu devotees to offer prayers?

(A) 1949 **(B)** 1984
(C) 1986 **(D)** 1992

Q7. Who was the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh who resigned immediately following the demolition of the Babri Masjid on 6 December 1992?

(A) Mulayam Singh Yadav **(B)** Kalyan Singh
(C) Mayawati **(D)** Rajnath Singh

Q8. Which judicial inquiry commission was appointed by the Government of India in December 1992 to investigate the sequence of events leading to the demolition of the Babri Masjid?

(A) Shah Commission **(B)** Liberhan Commission
(C) Sarkaria Commission **(D)** Nanavati Commission

Q9. In which landmark judgment did the Supreme Court uphold the dismissal of four BJP state governments in 1992, ruling that 'Secularism is part of the Basic Structure'?

(A) Kesavananda Bharati Case (1973) **(B)** Indra Sawhney Case (1992)
(C) S.R. Bommai Case (1994) **(D)** Minerva Mills Case (1980)

Q10. Following the communal violence in Gujarat in 2002, the Supreme Court famously transferred which high-profile riot trial outside Gujarat to Maharashtra?

(A) Godhra Sabarmati Express Trial **(B)** Best Bakery Case
(C) Gulbarg Society Case **(D)** Naroda Patiya Case

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. By June 1991, India's foreign currency reserves dropped to barely $1.2 billion, adequate for only about two weeks of essential imports, forcing structural LPG economic reforms.

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q2. Prof. M.D. Nanjundaswamy led the Karnataka Rajya Raitha Sangha (KRRS) in high-profile agitations against WTO intellectual property rules, multinational corporations, and seed patenting.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q3. Kanshi Ram established BAMCEF (Backward and Minority Communities Employees Federation) in 1978 as a non-electoral body of salaried public sector employees to build an intellectual and financial base.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q4. The Dalit Panthers was founded in Maharashtra (specifically in the slums of Bombay) in May 1972 by young writers and activists resisting entrenched rural caste atrocities.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q5. Namdeo Dhasal, a pathbreaking Marathi poet who wrote 'Golpitha', co-founded the Dalit Panthers alongside J.V. Pawar and Arjun Dangle in 1972.

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q6. In February 1986, the Faizabad District Judge ordered the locks of the Babri structure opened for Hindu worship, an event that escalated religious mobilization on both sides.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q7. Kalyan Singh headed the BJP state government in Uttar Pradesh; he submitted his resignation to the Governor on the evening of 6 December 1992 after the structure was demolished.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. The Justice M.S. Liberhan Commission of Inquiry was constituted in December 1992 to probe the Babri Masjid demolition; it submitted its findings in 2009.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q9. In S.R. Bommai vs Union of India (1994), a nine-judge constitutional bench ruled that secularism is a fundamental feature of the basic structure, validating the dismissal of four state governments.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q10. In the Best Bakery Case (Vadodara), the Supreme Court ordered a retrial outside Gujarat in Maharashtra to ensure fair, uninfluenced proceedings for victim-witness Zahira Sheikh.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q3 option B	Picking the political party instead of the employee federation	BAMCEF (1978) was the employees' union; BSP (1984) was the electoral party.
Q4 option A	Placing Dalit Panthers in UP	Dalit Panthers originated in Maharashtra (1972); BSP originated in UP/Punjab.
Q6 option D	Confusing the 1986 court order with the 1992 demolition	Locks were opened in February 1986; the structure was demolished on 6 December 1992.
Q7 option A	Picking the SP leader instead of BJP Chief Minister	Mulayam Singh was in opposition; Kalyan Singh was the ruling BJP Chief Minister who resigned.
Q8 option D	Picking the anti-Sikh riots commission	Nanavati Commission investigated 1984 anti-Sikh riots & 2002 Godhra; Liberhan investigated Babri demolition.